

HOUSE No. 4672

The Commonwealth of Massachusetts

HOUSE OF REPRESENTATIVES, October 28, 2025.

The committee on Ways and Means, to whom was referred the Bill relative to teacher preparation and student literacy (House, No. 4642), reports recommending that the same ought to pass with an amendment substituting therefor the accompanying bill (House, No. 4672).

For the committee,

AARON MICHLEWITZ.

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In the One Hundred and Ninety-Fourth General Court
(2025-2026)

An Act relative to teacher preparation and student literacy.

Be it enacted by the Senate and House of Representatives in General Court assembled, and by the authority of the same, as follows:

1 SECTION 1. Section 55A of chapter 15 of the General Laws, as appearing in the 2024
2 Official Edition, is hereby amended by striking out, in lines 56 to 59, inclusive, the words “(6)
3 review the progress of overall student achievement and; (7) evaluate student performance, school
4 and district management, overall district governance and any other areas deemed necessary by
5 the office” and inserting in place thereof the following words:- (6) evaluate the alignment of
6 literacy instructional materials and curricula with department-recommended evidence-based
7 literacy instruction and high-quality curricula, as those terms are defined in section 1E 1/2 of
8 chapter 69; (7) review the progress of overall student achievement; and (8) evaluate student
9 performance, school and district management, overall district governance and any other areas
10 deemed necessary by the office.

11 SECTION 2. Chapter 69 of the General Laws is hereby amended by inserting after
12 section 1E the following 2 sections:-

Section 1E 1/2. (a) As used in this section and section 1E 3/4, the following words shall, unless the context clearly requires otherwise, have the following meanings:

“Evidence-based literacy instruction”, literacy instruction that is: (i) grounded in scientific research methods; and (ii) demonstrated through well-designed and well-implemented studies to produce significant and positive effects on student learning outcomes.

“Five research-based areas in reading instruction”, reading instruction that includes, but shall not be limited to, phonemic awareness, phonics, fluency, vocabulary and comprehension.

“High-quality curriculum”, curriculum reviewed and approved by the department.

(b) No curricula selected to meet a curriculum framework pursuant to section 1E for kindergarten through grade 3 literacy shall include implicit and incidental instruction in word reading, visual memorization of whole words, guessing from context and picture cues, also known as MSV or three-cueing.

(c) Districts shall select high-quality curricula to meet the curriculum frameworks pursuant to section 1E for kindergarten through grade 3 literacy that: (i) include instruction in the five research-based areas in reading instruction; and (ii) utilize and are based upon evidence-based literacy instruction.

(d)(1) A district may apply to the department for a waiver to use kindergarten through grade 3 literacy instruction curriculum that does not appear on the department’s list of high-quality curricula.

(2) In determining whether to approve a district's waiver for a curriculum that is not already on the department's list of high-quality curricula, the department shall assess whether the district's curriculum utilizes evidence-based literacy instruction.

(e)(1) A district may apply to the department for a waiver to use a kindergarten through grade 3 literacy instruction curriculum pilot program that utilizes curricula that the department has not yet reviewed to determine if it is evidence-based literacy instruction.

(2) A district shall report to the department: (i) the degree to which the pilot's instructional approach is supported by some degree of scientific research; (ii) the methodology of the pilot; (iii) the population that was instructed using the pilot curriculum and any demographic differences between that population and the district's student body at large; (iv) the duration of any such pilot; and (v) any other considerations that the department deems relevant to the quality and fairness of the pilot program's execution and impact on student learning.

(3) In determining whether to approve a district's application to participate in a pilot program pursuant to this subsection, the department shall assess the quality of the proposed pilot program, including, information received pursuant to paragraph (2).

(4) Curriculum for a pilot program that is assessed and approved by the department and deemed to meet the requirements of this section shall be allowed to continue as an approved literacy curriculum used for instruction in the district unless the pilot program is rescinded pursuant to paragraph (7).

(5) A district that participates in a pilot program pursuant to this subsection shall publicly post to its website any report submitted to the department with information required pursuant to paragraph (2) and curriculum samples.

(6) The department may audit approved pilot programs at any time. The audit shall include, but shall not be limited to: (i) an in-depth review of curriculum materials; (ii) instructional documentation; and (iii) instructional practices in the classroom.

(7) The department may rescind approval of a pilot program based on audit findings before the expiration of the pilot program.

Section 1E ³/₄. (a) The department shall provide tools and resources to aid districts in providing professional development aligned with evidence-based literacy instruction for literacy teachers, paraprofessionals and reading specialists in kindergarten through grade 3.

(b) The department shall create and maintain:

(i) a list of department-approved professional development programs and vendors aligned with evidence-based literacy instruction best practices; and

(ii) a set of online training modules available and free to all teachers that provide training on the foundational practices and pedagogy aligned with evidence-based literacy instruction best practices.

SECTION 3. Section 1S of said chapter 69, as appearing in the 2024 Official Edition, is hereby amended by striking out, in line 41, the words “and (J)” and inserting in place thereof the following words:- (J) implementing literacy instructions based on evidence-based literacy instruction; and (K).

SECTION 4. Said section 1S of said chapter 69, as so appearing, is hereby further amended by inserting after the word “subgroups”, in line 48, the following words:- ; and

provided further, that district plans shall address implementation and compliance with section 1E 1/2.

SECTION 5. Said section 1S of said chapter 69, as so appearing, is hereby further amended by adding the following 2 subsections:-

(h)(1) Annually, not later than August 15, the department shall identify a list of data requirements that districts shall report on related to curricula consistent with evidence-based literacy instruction pursuant to section 1E 1/2. The department shall publish the list of data requirements on the department's website.

(2) Annually, not later than October 31, each district shall report to the department the data required by the department pursuant to paragraph (1).

(i) Annually, not later than December 31, the department shall aggregate data collected from each district pursuant to subsection (h), prepare and publish a report on the aggregated data and file the report with the clerks of the house of representatives and the senate and the joint committee on education. The department shall publish the report on the department's website.

SECTION 6. Section 2 of chapter 70 of the General Laws, as so appearing, is hereby amended by inserting after the definition of "Equalized property valuation" the following definition:-

"Evidence-based literacy instruction", as defined in section 1E 1/2 of chapter 69.

SECTION 7. Said section 2 of said chapter 70, as so appearing, is hereby further amended by inserting after the definition of "Excess effort" the following definition:-

“Five research-based areas in reading instruction”, as defined in section 1E ½ of chapter 69.

SECTION 8. Section 38G of chapter 71 of the General Laws, as so appearing, is hereby amended by striking out the twenty-fourth paragraph and inserting in place thereof the following 2 paragraphs:-

For the purposes of certifying educators, the board shall establish policies and guidelines and the commissioner may approve preparation programs devoted to the preparation of teachers and other educational personnel. Said policies and guidelines shall include alignment with evidence-based literacy instruction for educator preparation programs. The department shall require a fee for any application submitted to the department for review and approval of an educator preparation program. The secretary of administration and finance shall annually set the fee pursuant to section 3B of chapter 7 and the fee shall cover the costs pursuant to this paragraph. A college or university or school or district or other institution offering such an approved program shall certify to the commissioner that a candidate has demonstrated satisfactory competence in the skills and knowledge expected of college graduates in the most advanced nations and has completed the approved program.

The commissioner shall evaluate approved educator preparation programs to ensure that candidates are prepared to meet the needs of all students in the commonwealth. The commissioner shall meaningfully differentiate the performance of individual approved educator preparation program providers, including, but not limited to, quality and outcomes of candidates once they are employed. The review shall include, but shall not be limited to: (i) program implementation of evidence-based preparation in the five research-based areas in reading

instruction; and (ii) the extent to which new teachers' effectiveness addresses persistent disparities in achievement. The commissioner shall annually publish data on approved programs, including, but not limited to, the current approval status, enrollment, demographics of candidates, areas of licensure being pursued and employment rate of graduates.

SECTION 9. Section 57A of said chapter 71, as so appearing, is hereby amended by adding the following sentence:- The commissioner shall annually publish data on which screening assessments are employed by each school district, including, but not limited to, kindergarten through grade 3 literacy screening assessments and whether the screening assessments are approved by the department.

SECTION 10. Said chapter 71 is hereby further amended by inserting after section 57A the following 2 sections:-

Section 57B. (a) For the purposes of this section and section 57C, the term "screening assessments" shall mean tools and assessments that can be used to identify students at risk for poor academic outcomes as determined by the department.

(b) The department, in consultation with the department of early education and care, shall issue guidelines to districts requiring screening procedures and protocols for reading ability and progress in literacy skills for all students in kindergarten through grade 3 using screening assessments. The guidelines shall include a threshold at which a student is determined to be "significantly below" the grade level benchmark. The commissioner shall annually publish data on which screening assessments are employed by each district to conduct reading screening.

Section 57C. (a) Each district shall, not less than twice per year, assess each student's reading ability and progress in literacy skills from kindergarten through at least grade 3, using a

screening assessment approved by the department. The screening assessment of the student's reading ability and progress shall be consistent with section 2 of chapter 71B, the department's dyslexia guidelines issued pursuant to section 57A and literacy guidelines issued pursuant to section 57B.

(b) If a screening assessment determines that a student is significantly below relevant grade level benchmarks in specific literacy skills, the district shall determine which actions within the general education program will meet the student's needs, including, but not limited to, differentiated or supplementary evidence-based reading instruction and ongoing monitoring of progress. Not later than 30 days after a screening result that determines a student is significantly below the relevant grade level benchmark, the district shall inform the student's parent or guardian of the screening results and the school's response and shall offer the opportunity for a follow-up discussion.

SECTION 11. Chapter 238 of the acts of 2024 is hereby amended by striking out section 290 and inserting in place thereof the following section:-

SECTION 290. (a) As used in this section, "high-needs district" shall mean a school or district with a high percentage of low-income students and English learners, which may include a school or district implementing turnaround plans.

(b) The department of elementary and secondary education shall, subject to appropriation, develop and administer a pilot program, in partnership with a college, university, school, district or other institution offering a educator preparation program approved pursuant to section 38G of chapter 71 of the General Laws, for teacher apprenticeships during which participants shall complete a paid teaching apprenticeship for school years in a high-needs

district in a classroom with a highly proficient mentor teacher. The department of elementary and secondary education shall determine qualifications of a highly proficient mentor teacher using factors, including, but not limited to, recent evaluation ratings, student growth data and demonstrated evidence-based practices. The program shall provide funds to candidates to support earning a competitive wage, including, but not limited to, support for childcare, transportation, textbooks and other core expenses, to ensure a diverse cohort are able to fully participate.

(c) The department of elementary and secondary education shall promulgate regulations defining the apprenticeship and the target candidates to be admitted to the program.

(d)(1) Not later than 1 year after the completion of the pilot program, the department of elementary and secondary education shall file a report with the clerks of the house of representatives and the senate and the joint committee on education on the outcome of the pilot program. The report shall include, but shall not be limited to: (i) data on the demographics of participants, participants' licensure pass rates on the MTEL and hiring rates; and (ii) an assessment of the feasibility of applying for status as a United States Registered Apprenticeship.

(2) Not later than 3 years after the completion of the pilot program, the department of elementary and secondary education shall file a report with the clerks of the house of representatives and the senate and the joint committee on education, which shall include, but shall not be limited to, an evaluation of the impact of apprentices on student outcomes as compared to teachers not participating in the pilot program using student growth measures and an assessment of the feasibility of expanding to a teacher apprenticeship for all teacher candidates or all candidates in high-needs districts.

181 SECTION 12. The department of elementary and secondary education shall update or
182 promulgate new rules and regulations as it deems necessary to implement this act.

183 SECTION 13. School districts shall begin reporting required pursuant to paragraph (2) of
184 subsection (h) of section 1S of chapter 69 of the General Laws in the 2026-2027 school year.

185 SECTION 14. Not later than December 31, 2027, the department of elementary and
186 secondary education shall submit the first report required pursuant to subsection (i) of section 1S
187 of chapter 69 of the General Laws.